

Summary (max. 3,800 characters)

Transit systems are a key component of urban public policy. These systems intersect with broader transportation and urban land use issues and are therefore of great interest and practical import. In general terms, transit systems generate accessibility to opportunities that contribute to the economic operation of urban regions. But this is not the only service that transit systems provide, since they use space more efficiently than low-capacity vehicles (mainly private automobiles), and thus help to reduce congestion and result in lower emissions per capita. Furthermore, transit is an obligated form of transport for many members of the public who may not be able to own or use a private vehicle and increasingly supports many urban residents who choose not to own a vehicle. As such, transit systems also help to reduce transportation-related social exclusion, and support democratic participation in many essential activities.

Despite their importance in public policy, transit services are often offered without explicit mention of the principles that underpin their provision. Implicitly, transit is often seen as an economic service that must remain fiscally responsible. But while fiscal responsibility is an important consideration, it is not by any means the only one. In reality, many of the benefits of transit systems are non-monetary, and a tendency to see them mainly as economic services leads to a narrow approach that can blunt their attractiveness. Particularly, there are numerous examples where this leads to major inequities in terms of the distribution of the benefits and the costs of public transportation, while ignoring its role as a facilitator of democratic participation in society.

Planning for transit systems that are equitable and promote ideals of transportation equity and justice is an urgent task, especially as the limits of highly individualized transportation systems become clear. EquiTransit proposes to re-envision transit from a broader, more just perspective, and aims to create the knowledge and tools needed to realize this vision. This project follows on the heels of recent research initiatives in Canada, particularly the SSHRC-funded project Mobilizing Justice, which have broken new ground and made considerable progress towards more inclusive, equitable, and just transportation systems in Canada. EquiTransit builds on these foundations with a more targeted focus on public transportation.

Accordingly, the objective of EquiTransit is to generate novel, theoretically-sound and analytics-based equity indicators useful to assess the performance of public transit systems in Canada. Theoretically, we will use a framework of justice that emphasizes the 5WH approach (why, what, who, where, when, how). To ensure that our indicators are pertinent to the question of "why equity?", we propose a Codesign approach, whereby the research team will work with transit operators and users in the explicit identification of the rationale and motivation for the development and use of indicators. We plan to use cutting-edge geospatial technologies to investigate the questions "who seeks equity, and where and when?". Further, we propose to create open-source tools, including equity-informed planning and assessment tools, and place them at the fingertips of stakeholders at the lowest possible cost. Finally, in the spirit of Codesign, the effectiveness of the tools will be assessed in consultation with stakeholders, so that refinements can be incorporated in successive releases of the tools. In this way, EquiTransit aims to produce actionable knowledge to support the development of more equitable transit in Canada, to the benefit of urban residents, democratic governance, and democratic participation in Canadian society.